

RAKSHANDA KHAUNTE

Redefining luxury experiences in Goa

In today's evolving entrepreneurial landscape, young women are emerging as drivers of innovation, change and leadership. Women are not only building enterprises but also creating spaces where opportunity, mentorship and community can grow.

Among the new generation is Rakshanda Khaunte, a young entrepreneur from Goa who discovered her leadership potential and built confidence while pursuing her degree in the United Kingdom. With a Bachelor's degree in Business Management from Cardiff University, she says, "I've always had a natural inclination toward leadership, but it was during my time in the UK that I truly stepped into it." Reflecting on her professional journey, Rakshanda shares: "Right from my childhood, I treated every summer as a learning opportunity. What began as hobbies evolved into internships across Goa and India. Between 16 and 22, I explored diverse industries including editorial, public relations, strategic partnerships, social media marketing and operations. Each role strengthened a different skillset and gave me a real understanding of how businesses function on the ground."

Following her graduation, Khaunte secured a role at a tech start-up in London, where she witnessed the fast-paced realities of a young company. She later moved to one of India's largest companies in London, where she was closely mentored by a self-made billionaire. "Together, these experiences gave me insight into both sides of the spectrum – the hunger of a start-up and the structure of an empire – shaping how I think, build and lead today," Khaunte states.

Since returning to Goa, Khaunte has been involved in elevating her family's luxury yacht business, and more recently, stepping into the hospitality space with the launch of her riverside restaurant.

Nestled along the Mandovi river, in a quaint village outside Panjim, her restaurant, _***Copita - Riverside Bistro and Bar,***_ is an ode to reviving Goa's peaceful, unhurried way of living. "My vision for the restaurant was to create a space people return to not just for the food, but for how it makes them feel," she shares.

The menu reflects global flavours inspired by Khaunte's travels, blended with tastes that feel comforting and nostalgic; flavourful dishes that retain the warm feeling of home.

Stepping into the hospitality space without formal industry experience, Khaunte faced her share of challenges, however, she believes: "Sometimes not knowing the 'rules' allows you to build something more instinctive and honest."

While entering a new industry, Khaunte's journey to entrepreneurship began along the same waters that overlook her restaurant today.

In 2022, she launched _***Mi Amor***_ with the aim of redefining luxury experiences in Goa and creating a new benchmark for luxury yachts in Goa. "I felt strongly that experiential, world-class yachting could exist at home – rooted in local beauty but executed with global standards," she says.

Looking ahead for the brand, her plan is to train local talent, strengthen marine infrastructure, and create experiences that feel both international and authentically Goan. "My long-term goal is sustainable expansion that enhances the state's



luxury tourism landscape while staying true to its soul."

Khaunte credits her entrepreneurial journey to her family and a strong circle of women. "When women genuinely champion each other – without competition, without insecurity – it creates a safe space to grow, take risks and evolve. I truly believe that surrounding yourself with strong, secure women is one of the greatest advantages any entrepreneur can have."

She further adds: "Women supporting women is not just a phrase – it's a powerful, grounding force. As they elevate you, you must do the same for them. The strongest circles are built on mutual encouragement, shared vision, and a genuine desire to see one another succeed. When that foundation exists, growth becomes collective, not competitive."